SAMPLE

Gratitude: The Response to the Giver

Shukr (شكر) in the Quran

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Introduction: The Recognition

The Quran describes gratitude -- *Shukr* -- as the response of the servant to the generosity of the Giver, the recognition of the blessing from the Bestower, and the acknowledgment of the gift from the Source. The Quran says: "And whoever is grateful is grateful for the benefit of himself" (31:12). Gratitude is the recognition -- the recognition that sees the gift, the recognition that acknowledges the giver, and the recognition that responds with the thankfulness. The gratitude is not merely the feeling but the action -- the action of the heart that appreciates, the action of the tongue that expresses, and the action of the limbs that use the blessing in the way of the Giver.

The word *Shukr* (شكر) comes from the root Sh-K-R (ش ك ر), which carries the meanings of thankfulness, gratitude, and appreciation. The verb *shakara* means to be grateful -- to acknowledge the favor, to appreciate the gift, and to respond to the blessing. The noun *Shukr* signifies the gratitude -- the gratitude that is the recognition, the gratitude that is the acknowledgment, and the gratitude that is the response. *Al-Shukr* is the gratitude that is the quality of the believer -- the quality that sees the Giver behind the gift, the quality that acknowledges the Source behind the blessing, and the quality that responds with the thankfulness to the Bestower.

This book -- the fifth in the Lessons from the Qur'an sub-series -- explores gratitude as the Quran describes it. It examines the name *Shukr*, Allah as the Source of all blessings, the command to be grateful, the warning about ingratitude (the few who are grateful), how gratitude multiplies blessings, the prophetic models of thankfulness, the relationship between patience and gratitude as the two wings of the believer, the denier of blessings, and the lesson -- how to live in the gratitude.

The Quran's treatment of gratitude reveals the dimension of the recognition -- the recognition that is the heart of the relationship between the servant and the Giver, the recognition that transforms the possession into the trust, and the recognition that changes the enjoyment into the worship. The gratitude is not only the response to the gift but the response to the Giver -- the Giver who is the Source of every blessing, the Origin of every good, and the Bestower of every gift.

The first chapter begins with the name itself -- what *Shukr* means, how the Quran uses it, and what the name reveals about the recognition it describes.

Chapter 1: The Name -- Shukr and the Meaning of Gratitude

The word *Al-Shukr* (الشكر) comes from the root Sh-K-R (ش ك ر), which carries the meanings of thankfulness, gratitude, appreciation, and acknowledgment. The verb *shakara* means to be grateful -- to acknowledge the favor, to appreciate the gift, and to respond to the blessing. The noun *Shukr* signifies the gratitude -- the gratitude that is the recognition of the gift, the gratitude that is the acknowledgment of the giver, and the gratitude that is the response to the blessing. The name tells the listener: this is not merely the feeling of appreciation but the active recognition that the gift came from the Giver, that the blessing came from the Source, and that the good came from the Bestower.

The Quran uses the word *Shukr* extensively. As the command: "And be grateful to Allah" (2:172). As the benefit: "And whoever is grateful is grateful for the benefit of himself" (31:12). As the warning: "And few of My servants are grateful" (34:13, broader context). As the increase: "If you are grateful, I will surely increase you" (14:7). As the quality of the believers: "And those who are grateful when they give" (76:8-9, broader context of the righteous). Each usage places *Shukr* as the central quality of the believer -- the quality that defines the relationship with the Giver, the quality that determines the increase of the blessing, and the quality that distinguishes the faithful from the forgetful.

The *Shukr* is the recognition -- the recognition that sees the gift in the blessing, the recognition that sees the Giver behind the gift, and the recognition that sees the Source behind the blessing. The Quran says: "And whatever you have of favor, it is from Allah" (16:53). The recognition is the seeing: the seeing that every good is from Allah, the seeing that every blessing is from the Giver, and the seeing that every gift is from the Source. The recognition is the understanding: the understanding that the possession is not earned but given, the understanding that the enjoyment is not deserved but granted, and the understanding that the blessing is not merited but bestowed. The recognition is the awareness: the awareness that the person is the recipient, the awareness that the person is the beneficiary, and the awareness that the person is the servant.

The scholars describe three dimensions of gratitude: the gratitude of the heart, the gratitude of the tongue, and the gratitude of the limbs. The gratitude of the heart is the inner appreciation -- the appreciation that feels the value of the gift, the appreciation that recognizes the generosity of the Giver, and the appreciation that treasures the blessing. The gratitude of the tongue is the verbal expression -- the expression that says *alhamdulillah*, the expression that praises the Giver, and the expression that acknowledges the gift. The gratitude of the limbs is the action -- the action that uses the blessing in the way of the Giver, the action that does not misuse the gift, and the action that serves the Giver with the blessing.

The gratitude of the heart is the inner recognition -- the recognition that is the awareness, the recognition that is the appreciation, and the recognition that is the love. The Quran says: "And Allah brought you forth from the wombs of your mothers not knowing anything, and He made for you hearing and vision and hearts that perhaps you would be grateful" (16:78). The heart's gratitude is the awareness: the awareness of the gift, the awareness of the Giver, and the awareness of the blessing. The heart's gratitude is the appreciation: the appreciation of the value, the appreciation of the generosity, and the appreciation of the kindness. The heart's gratitude is the love: the love for the Giver, the love for the Source, and the love for the Bestower.

The gratitude of the tongue is the verbal expression -- the expression that praises, the expression that acknowledges, and the expression that proclaims. The Quran says: "And as for the favor of your Lord, proclaim it" (93:11). The tongue's gratitude is the praise: the praise that says *alhamdulillah*, the praise that declares the goodness, and the praise that announces the generosity. The tongue's gratitude is the acknowledgment: the acknowledgment that the gift is from Allah, the acknowledgment that the blessing is from the Giver, and the acknowledgment that the good is from the Source. The tongue's gratitude is the proclamation: the proclamation that shares the good, the proclamation that spreads the joy, and the proclamation that declares the grace.

The gratitude of the limbs is the action -- the action that uses the blessing rightly, the action that does not waste the gift, and the action that serves the Giver with the blessing. The Quran says: "And establish prayer for My remembrance" (20:14). The limbs' gratitude is the use: the use of the eyes to see the truth, the use of the ears to hear the guidance, and the use of the hands to do the good. The limbs' gratitude is the service: the service that uses the blessing for the Giver, the service that uses the gift for the Lord, and the service that uses the good for the Source. The limbs' gratitude is the worship: the worship that is the gratitude in action, the worship that is the thankfulness in practice, and the worship that is the appreciation in deed.

The name *Shukr* is the relationship -- the relationship between the servant and the Giver, the relationship that is defined by the recognition, and the relationship that is maintained by the gratitude. The Quran says: "And whoever is grateful is grateful for the benefit of himself" (31:12). The relationship is the response: the response to the gift, the response to the blessing, and the response to the good. The relationship is the connection: the connection that is maintained by the gratitude, the connection that is deepened by the acknowledgment, and the connection that is strengthened by the appreciation. The person who is grateful is the person who is in the relationship -- the relationship with the Giver, the relationship with the Source, and the relationship with the Bestower.
